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Democrats probe Epstein's ties with foreign governments



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Rep. Jamie Raskin (D-Md.) speaks in Longworth building on June 10. Photo: Tom Williams/CQ-Roll Call, Inc via Getty Images

Convicted sex offender [Jeffrey Epstein](#) may have acted as an unregistered foreign agent — and tried to leverage his past relationship with [President Trump](#), when doing so, the top Democrat on the House Judiciary Committee alleged in a letter demanding records.

The big picture: Rep. Jamie Raskin's (D-Md.) inquiry previews the types of investigations the party could launch with subpoena power if they retake a chamber this fall.

Driving the news: Raskin [wrote](#) to administration officials that the Epstein files show the disgraced financier seemingly tried to become an emissary for Saudi Arabia and appeared to advise leaders in Kuwait, Israel and Russia.

- In one [exchange](#), Epstein appeared to pitch himself to Saudi Arabia as a "Financial Confidant to the Prince

/court / Ks.a whatever entity suits you . . .I am happy to represent KSA interests. period."

- Raskin wrote that Epstein's "close relationship" with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman "became obvious" in the emails.
- There were also indications Epstein coached the Kuwaiti emir on how to deal with Trump, the letter alleges. Epstein [told](#) a redacted sender in 2017 there was "much to do around the trump trip" and asked what "concrete" things the emir would "like to see happen from the US."

The letter also alleged Epstein advised former Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Barak, serving as his "sherpa through U.S.-Russia-Middle East diplomacy," and, "most disturbingly ... appeared to give advice on how to handle President Trump to high-level officials in Russia."

- Epstein [appeared](#) to have given Russia's late United Nations representative, Vitaly Churkin, advice on Trump, writing in 2018, "churkin was great. he understood trump after our conversations, it is not complex. he must be seen to get something its that simple."

What he's saying: "Jeffrey Epstein never registered as a foreign agent," Raskin wrote to acting Attorney General Todd Blanche, Secretary of State Marco Rubio and and Jay Clayton, the U.S. attorney for the Southern District of New York and Trump's nominee for director of national intelligence.

- "Yet numerous recently released documents now show he acted aggressively on behalf of multiple foreign governments, including several with interests adverse to the United States, in order to influence policies of the first Trump Administration," he continued.
- Raskin warned that Epstein's ties with foreign leaders posed a major national security liability and raised questions about what information he could have fed them about the president.

White House spokesperson Abigail Jackson said in a statement to Axios, "Just as President Trump has said, he's been totally exonerated on anything relating to Epstein."

- The DOJ did not immediately respond to Axios' request for comment.

What we're watching: Raskin gave the government until 5pm on Aug. 3 to provide records tied to Epstein's contacts with 19 nations — including Saudi Arabia, Israel, Kuwait, Russia and Qatar — as well as entities that may have been structured to avoid federal registration.

- He also asked DOJ whether there have ever been Foreign Agents Registration Act investigations into Epstein and, if not, why it hadn't initiated any.
- FARA requires what its name suggests: for foreign agents representing or doing advocacy work on behalf of foreign governments, people or organizations to register with the DOJ.

The bottom line: The files exposed the breadth of Epstein's far-reaching business and political web, prompting additional [investigations](#) and [derailing careers](#).

- And the web keeps unraveling, piling [political and legal pressure](#) on the administration to [release withheld records](#).

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